

BusyBee: Contextual Inquiry Interviews

CSC 310 Human-Computer Interaction | Team: Omar Naguib, Nolan Jarvinen, Evan Wilkin

Each team member conducted a structured interview with real participants using the same ten questions below. Seven interviews were completed across the team. Responses are recorded as given.

Participants

Subject	Interviewed by
Subject 1	Omar Naguib
Subject 2	Omar Naguib
Subject 3	Evan Wilkin
Subject 4	Evan Wilkin
Subject 5	Evan Wilkin
Subject 6	Nolan Jarvinen
Subject 7	Nolan Jarvinen

Interview Questions

1. How often do you go out?
2. Do you plan ahead before going out, or are you more spontaneous?
3. How important is knowing an establishment's busyness to you?
4. What methods, if any, do you use to find the predicted or expected wait time?
5. What do you do when you can't tell how busy a place is going to be?
6. How often do you end up somewhere more crowded than you like?
7. How do you feel when a place is busier or has a longer wait than you expected?
8. How bad does the busyness or wait time need to be for you to consider leaving and trying another place?
9. Have you ever told someone else how busy a place was?
10. Would you trust a community-based predicted wait time or busyness app?

Subject 1

Question	Response
How often do you go out?	Most days, in some form. Being retired means the week doesn't have the shape it used to have. Groceries, the gym a couple of times, dinner out with my wife maybe twice. And there's the travel, which is the big one. Six or eight trips a year, seeing family or just going somewhere.
Do you plan ahead before going out, or are you more spontaneous?	Depends entirely on what it is. Dinner locally, we'll just go, and if there's a wait we'll go somewhere else or sit at the bar. No harm done. Flying, I plan it to the minute. I'm working backwards from boarding time the night before. There's nothing spontaneous about it, and I don't think I'd enjoy it if there was.
How important is knowing an establishment's busyness to you?	For a restaurant it's nice to know. It changes whether we go at six or at seven. It isn't going to ruin the evening either way. At an airport it's the single thing I'd most like to know and can't. Everything else about that morning I can control. The security line is the one part I'm guessing at, and it's the part that decides whether I make the flight.
What methods, if any, do you use to find the predicted or expected wait time?	For restaurants we'll just ring them and ask. Somebody picks up, tells you forty minutes, and that's that. For the airport there's the wait time they publish and I've stopped trusting it. It told me ten minutes once and I stood there the better part of forty. I don't know whether it was wrong or whether it was just old, and that's the part that bothers me. So mostly now I ask people. My wife goes through a different checkpoint and texts me which one is moving. The shuttle driver has done forty runs that morning, he knows which terminal is a mess.
What do you do when you can't tell how busy a place is going to be?	I add more time. That's the whole strategy, there isn't a second one. If it's a holiday, or I've got a connection I can't afford to miss, another forty five minutes on top. The cost of being early is a coffee and a magazine. The cost of being late is a missed flight, a rebooking fee and a night in a hotel. Those aren't the same size, so I don't treat them the same.
How often do you end up somewhere more crowded than you like?	More than I'd like to admit. A few times a year at the airport, where it actually matters. Locally, maybe once a month we'll walk somewhere on a Saturday and turn straight around. The airport ones stay with you though. The restaurant ones you've forgotten by the next day.
How do you feel when a place is busier or has a longer wait than you expected?	At a restaurant, mildly irritated, and then over it. At the airport it isn't irritation, it's a low level dread that builds the whole time you're standing there. You're doing the arithmetic over and over. If this line takes another fifteen minutes, where does that put me. And you can't do anything with the feeling, that's the worst part of it. You're just stuck in it.
How bad does the busyness or wait time need to be for you to consider leaving and trying another place?	For dinner, twenty minutes and we'll look elsewhere. Thirty and we definitely will. At the airport there is no leaving. That's the whole point of it. You can't decide the line is too long and go to a different airport. You stand in it for however long it is. Which is exactly why I'd want to know before I left the house, because that's the only moment I've got any choice in it.
Have you ever told someone else how busy a place was?	All the time, to the family. We've got a group message and I'll send "leave now, security is a zoo" if I've just come through it. You've stood in it, you don't want the next person standing in it. Somewhere public, for strangers, I wouldn't think to. Who's reading it? What am I getting out of it?
Would you trust a community-based predicted wait time or busyness app?	More than the official number, I think, provided I could see when it was posted. Somebody who was standing there ten minutes ago is telling me something real. A sign is telling me what somebody typed in at some point. But I'd want to know how many people said it. One person could be at the wrong terminal, or just wrong. And if it was an hour old I'd ignore it, same as I ignore the signs now.

Subject 2

Question	Response
How often do you go out?	Every day basically, if going out counts as leaving the house. I'm on campus five days a week and I never study at home, so that's a cafe or the library most days. Then dinner with friends a couple of times a week, more at the weekend.
Do you plan ahead before going out, or are you more spontaneous?	For studying, zero planning. Class ends and I walk somewhere. The gap is however long it is, so thinking about it just eats into it. Going out with friends is the opposite, except it isn't really planning, it's negotiating. Six people in a group chat for twenty minutes. Someone suggests a place, someone checks Maps, someone says they went last Friday and it was awful.
How important is knowing an establishment's busyness to you?	Really important for studying, and I don't think I'd realised that until you asked. Busy means no table, and no table means the whole trip was pointless. For going out it matters in the opposite direction. If a place is dead on a Friday night I don't want to go. You want it to be busy, that's the whole point of going out.
What methods, if any, do you use to find the predicted or expected wait time?	Google Maps has the popular times thing, and it's a vibe. It's right about the general shape, lunch is busy obviously, but it doesn't know anything about today. It doesn't know it's midterms. During finals every cafe near the library is full at eleven at night and the graph says quiet, because normally it would be. Mostly I just message someone who's there. If someone from my course is at the library I'll ask if there's space, and that's better than any app because they're looking right at it. And sometimes I'll check whether a place got tagged on Instagram recently, you can tell from a story whether it's rammed.
What do you do when you can't tell how busy a place is going to be?	I just go. It's a five minute walk, and if it's full I'll go somewhere else. It's not a big deal any one time. Although if I actually think about it, that happens a lot, and it adds up. Twenty minutes here, twenty there. Some weeks I feel like I've spent half my study time looking for somewhere to study.
How often do you end up somewhere more crowded than you like?	Honestly, weekly. Probably more during midterms and finals. It's so normal that I don't really register it as a thing that's going wrong. It's just what happens.
How do you feel when a place is busier or has a longer wait than you expected?	Annoyed, but mostly at myself, which is stupid because there was no way for me to know. And if I'm on my own there's a bit of embarrassment in walking in, seeing it's full, and having to turn round and walk straight back out. Everyone watches you do it. It's not a big thing but I'd rather not.
How bad does the busyness or wait time need to be for you to consider leaving and trying another place?	For studying it isn't about the wait at all, it's just binary. Either there's a table or there isn't. If there's nowhere to sit I've already left, there's nothing to wait for. For dinner with friends we'd wait half an hour easily, if it's somewhere we actually wanted to go. Longer if we've already walked there. And once six people have agreed on something, nobody wants to reopen it.
Have you ever told someone else how busy a place was?	Constantly. I'll take a photo of the place and send it to the group with something like "do not come here." That's just normal. I wouldn't write a review about it though. It's a thing you tell your friends, it isn't information, it's just complaining.
Would you trust a community-based predicted wait time or busyness app?	I'd try it. Whether I'd keep it depends on whether it's ever right when I check it, and I'd work that out within about two weeks. I'd trust it more than Maps because at least it's about today. But it only works if people actually use it. An app like that near campus with nobody posting is just an empty map, and I'd delete it. It would need to be quick, too. If reporting takes more than a couple of seconds I'm not doing it, I'm already walking.

Subject 3

Question	Response
How often do you go out?	Once every three weeks (sitting down, not ordering take out).
Do you plan ahead before going out, or are you more spontaneous?	Typically chooses what establishment to visit, but doesn't necessarily research where they want to go.
How important is knowing an establishment's busyness to you?	Medium. Nobody wants to wait or be crowded, but where they go, it isn't a huge concern.
What methods, if any, do you use to find the predicted or expected wait time?	Will look at the predicted busyness through Google, or if it is a movie theater will check how many seats are bought. Checks online casually and infrequently.
What do you do when you can't tell how busy a place is going to be?	Debates the desire versus the potential wait.
How often do you end up somewhere more crowded than you like?	Pretty rarely, about 4 times a year, due to the infrequency of going out (separate from daily highway traffic).
How do you feel when a place is busier or has a longer wait than you expected?	Moderately inconvenienced to discouraged.
How bad does the busyness or wait time need to be for you to consider leaving and trying another place?	Any wait time is too much when going with a family with two young children.
Have you ever told someone else how busy a place was?	Yes, both when a friend is coming to meet up or when they are going separately, will let them know.
Would you trust a community-based predicted wait time or busyness app?	As a starting point, as long as there is active community use. Sees no reason for someone to rate a place not busy when it is. Already trusts apps such as GasBuddy.

Subject 4

Question	Response
How often do you go out?	3 to 4 times a day, most likely 3.
Do you plan ahead before going out, or are you more spontaneous?	Always plans ahead. Last thing they want is to walk around not knowing what they need.
How important is knowing an establishment's busyness to you?	Depends on the establishment. Doesn't want to go to the gym when it is packed since it's a smaller sized gym. Grocery stores are also a mess when busy, wants to get in and out.
What methods, if any, do you use to find the predicted or expected wait time?	Google predicted busyness.
What do you do when you can't tell how busy a place is going to be?	Just goes and risks it being busier than normal.
How often do you end up somewhere more crowded than you like?	Happens about 2 to 3 times a week. Even going to the gym at 6 a.m. is busier than expected.
How do you feel when a place is busier or has a longer wait than you expected?	Stressed about wasting time.
How bad does the busyness or wait time need to be for you to consider leaving and trying another place?	10 minutes or more will cause them to leave.
Have you ever told someone else how busy a place was?	Maybe like once.
Would you trust a community-based predicted wait time or busyness app?	Doesn't know, maybe. Would have to trial and error it.

Subject 5

Question	Response
How often do you go out?	At least once or twice every week.
Do you plan ahead before going out, or are you more spontaneous?	Usually a plan ahead type of person.
How important is knowing an establishment's busyness to you?	Not super important. Nice to know ahead, but if it's busy when they get there, they'll just wait.
What methods, if any, do you use to find the predicted or expected wait time?	Usually just a Google based wait time.
What do you do when you can't tell how busy a place is going to be?	Still goes anyway. If it's too busy, just goes somewhere else.
How often do you end up somewhere more crowded than you like?	Pretty often, probably once every week.
How do you feel when a place is busier or has a longer wait than you expected?	It sucks but will put up with it, especially if it's a restaurant they want to eat at.
How bad does the busyness or wait time need to be for you to consider leaving and trying another place?	15 minutes is the average wait time. If already seated, will wait 20 minutes for a waiter before trying to flag someone down, and will only leave if that doesn't work.
Have you ever told someone else how busy a place was?	Yes. If they are coming to meet up, they'll let them know before heading over. If someone asks about a restaurant, they'll give their prediction.
Would you trust a community-based predicted wait time or busyness app?	Yes, if the results are reliable and there is a community already using it.

Subject 6

Question	Response
How often do you go out?	I go out almost every day. Usually there is something I need to do, like going to a store or getting something to eat.
Do you plan ahead before going out, or are you more spontaneous?	I usually plan ahead before I go somewhere. I like knowing where I'm going and having an idea of how long I will be there.
How important is knowing an establishment's busyness to you?	Pretty important. I don't really like being around a lot of people, so if I know a place is going to be really crowded, I wouldn't typically go, or I would look for another place depending on where it is I would be going.
What methods, if any, do you use to find the predicted or expected wait time?	I don't really use anything right now to check wait times or how busy somewhere is before I go. Most of the time I just go there and find out once I arrive.
What do you do when you can't tell how busy a place is going to be?	I'll go to the business and see how busy it is when I get there.
How often do you end up somewhere more crowded than you like?	Probably more than half of the time that I go out. It happens pretty frequently, especially when I go somewhere at a time when a lot of other people are out too.
How do you feel when a place is busier or has a longer wait than you expected?	It makes me anxious, especially when a place is much more crowded than I was expecting.
How bad does the busyness or wait time need to be for you to consider leaving and trying another place?	For a restaurant, if the wait is over about 30 minutes, I would probably consider going somewhere else. I also wouldn't really want to stay for a movie if the theater was extremely crowded. Stores are different though. If a store is busy, I'll typically still go in and get what I need.
Have you ever told someone else how busy a place was?	Probably. I've definitely talked about how busy places are. If I knew someone else was thinking about going there, I might tell them how crowded it was.
Would you trust a community-based predicted wait time or busyness app?	Probably, as long as the app was run well and the information seemed accurate. I already use Waze, which relies on others reporting things like traffic, accidents, and other conditions, so I could see myself using something similar to find out how busy a business is.

Subject 7

Question	Response
How often do you go out?	If we're counting anywhere or anything, I leave the house almost every day. I go to the gym six days a week, the store about once a week, and then I have work, or I'll drive all the way to Flint, so I'm usually going somewhere every day.
Do you plan ahead before going out, or are you more spontaneous?	I think it depends on what I have going on that day. If I'm doing something like golfing, I'll have a plan to go golfing, but whatever I do after might be spontaneous. For things like going to the grocery store or the gym, I usually know ahead of time that I'm going.
How important is knowing an establishment's busyness to you?	Somewhat important. If it's a restaurant, I like knowing whether or not it's busy, but for something like a grocery store, I don't care as much. If I'm going to downtown Detroit, it's more important because I want to know what traffic and parking are going to be like. It would also be nice to know if something like a golf course is really busy.
What methods, if any, do you use to find the predicted or expected wait time?	I'll usually check Google Maps or Apple Maps to see how long the drive is and what traffic looks like. For restaurants, I'll look online to see if there are reservations available or if they have a wait time posted. Sometimes I'll call ahead and ask how busy they are or if they have any tables open.
What do you do when you can't tell how busy a place is going to be?	Usually I'll just take my chances and go there. If I get there and it's too busy, I'll just go somewhere else.
How often do you end up somewhere more crowded than you like?	If we're talking about traffic, every day. For actual places, I'd say maybe 25% of the time. I'm usually pretty good at predicting when somewhere is going to be busy and trying to beat the crowd.
How do you feel when a place is busier or has a longer wait than you expected?	It's more of an "aw man" or "dang it" kind of feeling. Like I wanted to eat or hang out there, and now I might have to change plans. I don't know how to describe the emotion, really. It's annoying I guess.
How bad does the busyness or wait time need to be for you to consider leaving and trying another place?	For a restaurant, around 45 minutes is usually my cutoff, especially depending on how hungry I am. If I could get a drink or something while I waited, I might stay longer. For stores, it would have to be really busy. The Costco in Ann Arbor can get packed, and seeing a really full parking lot or really long checkout lines can get frustrating.
Have you ever told someone else how busy a place was?	Yeah. I can't really think of a specific time, but if I'm meeting someone somewhere and I get there first, I'll usually let them know if it's really busy. Then we can decide if we want to go somewhere else.
Would you trust a community-based predicted wait time or busyness app?	I would, but it would have to be done the right way. I'd want to know how they make sure the information is trustworthy. If the app explained how it deals with false reports, trolls, and moderation, I'd be more likely to trust what people are reporting.

Key Takeaways

1. **Trust in any busyness source is always conditional, never a blanket yes.** Every subject qualified their answer: a timestamp and a headcount of reporters (Subject 1), two weeks of proof plus enough nearby users (Subject 2), trial and error (Subject 4), a track record and an existing community (Subjects 3, 5), a well-run and accurate app (Subject 6), and an explanation of how false reports and trolls get handled (Subject 7).
2. **A person who is there right now is trusted over any app, sign, or published number.** Subject 1 asks his wife and a shuttle driver. Subject 2 messages someone already at the library. Subject 5 calls the restaurant directly. Subject 7 calls ahead to ask if tables are open.
3. **How much busyness matters depends on the stakes of that specific trip, not a fixed priority.** Subject 1 treats a restaurant wait as trivial and an airport line as the one thing that decides if he makes his flight. Subject 2 treats a full table as pass or fail for studying but wants a place busy when out with friends. Subject 7 cares for a restaurant or downtown parking, not for a grocery run. Subject 3 barely cares in general but raises the stakes explicitly around a family with young children.
4. **People already tell each other how busy a place is, but only people they already know, and they don't think of it as reporting.** Subject 1 texts family, not strangers (“who's reading it, what am I getting out of it”). Subject 2 posts photos to a group chat constantly but calls it complaining, not information. Subjects 3, 4, 5, and 7 all say yes, but only when meeting someone or asked directly.
5. **Existing tools are known to fail in specific ways, so people build their own workarounds instead of trusting them.** Subject 1's airport wait time said ten minutes and was forty. Subject 2's Google popular times “doesn't know it's midterms.” Subject 6 uses nothing right now and just finds out on arrival. Subject 7 pairs Maps traffic with a phone call because neither alone is enough.
6. **The cost of being wrong drives behavior more than how often it happens.** Subject 1 states it outright: a coffee and a wait versus a missed flight and a hotel room “aren't the same size.” Subject 2 treats a wasted trip to a full cafe as a binary loss. Subject 3 sets a lower tolerance specifically because of young kids in tow. Subject 6 will still enter a busy store to get what she needs but won't stay for a crowded movie.
7. **Reactions scale with stakes and visibility, from mild annoyance to real dread.** Subject 1 describes a low level dread and helplessness at the airport versus being mildly irritated at a restaurant. Subject 6 says it makes her anxious. Subject 2 is annoyed at herself and also embarrassed walking back out in front of others. Subject 4 feels stressed about wasting time. Subject 7's reaction is the mildest: “aw man, dang it.”